

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- The story of the day: a Guardian analysis of police FOI data (33 of England and Wales' 43 forces) finds at least 8,500 recorded sexual offences against under-13s on or near school premises between 2021-25 - nearly five a day, including close to 2,000 rapes or attempted rapes.
→ **For your school:** Worth revisiting how confidently pupils know how - and to whom - to report concerns, and whether records distinguish peer-on-peer incidents clearly enough to spot patterns.
- A quieter day otherwise for national DfE announcements - today's main fixture is the National Alternative Provision Conference on SEND reform and inclusion-first accountability (see diary).

DATES FOR THE DIARY

- 7 Oct 2026** — National Alternative Provision Conference examines SEND reform and inclusion-first accountability.
- 8 Oct 2026** — DfE pupil premium quarter 2 payments for 2026/27 made to academies.
- 16 Oct 2026** — Midday deadline for Sheffield secondary school applications for September 2027 entry (national deadline 31 Oct).
- 26-30 Oct 2026** — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

■ NATIONAL: NEAR-DAILY SEXUAL OFFENCES RECORDED IN OR NEAR SCHOOLS, GUARDIAN ANALYSIS FINDS

- **FOI data from two-thirds of forces shows thousands of recorded offences against under-13s.** At least 8,500 sexual offences against under-13s were recorded on or near school premises in England and Wales between 2021 and 2025 - nearly five a day - including close to 2,000 rapes or attempted rapes; about two-thirds of under-13 victims were girls, and most identified alleged offenders were themselves children. Only 33 of 43 forces supplied data, so the true total is almost certainly higher. ([The Guardian](#))
→ **For your school:** Worth checking harmful sexual behaviour training and reporting routes are current, especially for younger pupils and SEND pupils who may be less able to flag concerns.

■ SHEFFIELD: GCSE TABLE LANDS AHEAD OF Y7 ADMISSIONS DEADLINE

- **A round-up of Sheffield secondaries' GCSE grades arrives as the local application deadline nears.** The Star's look at Sheffield secondary schools' GCSE performance lands with the city's non-selective deadline to apply for September 2027 Year 7 places approaching on 16 October (national deadline 31 October) - useful context for parents weighing options this half term. ([The Star](#))
→ **For your school:** Pastoral and admissions leads may want it on hand for parent queries before half term.

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

8,500+

recorded sexual offences against under-13s in or near schools in England & Wales, 2021-25 - from

just 33 of 43 police forces, so the true toll is almost certainly higher.

The Guardian FOI analysis, Oct 2026

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; “Who’s Losing Learning?”
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.